THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

Series Bible — Document 06: World Building — America & the World on January 1, 2023

Opening Image

It's the first morning of 2023. America is exhausted. In three years it has lived through a pandemic, an insurrection, the highest inflation in 40 years, and a war in Europe it's paying for but not fighting. The President is 80. The man who wants his job back is 76. The country's most beloved person is a 30-year-old former child star whose company's bluebird is on every child's backpack. He has never once said he wants to be President.

Our world is the real world plus a few deliberate divergences. Everything before April 20, 2023 happened as in real life, except where the Donohues, the Bullocks, the Smilleys, or our fictional characters were involved. Those divergences are listed in Section 6.

1. State of the Nation Dashboard (as of Jan 1, 2023)

Indicator	Value	What it feels like
U.S. population	About 334 million	
President	Joe Biden (D), 80	The oldest President in history. Approval in the low 40s.
Vice President	Kamala Harris (D), 58	
Inflation (CPI, Dec 2022)	6.5% year over year	Down from the 9.1% peak in June 2022, but groceries still hurt.
Unemployment	3.5%	Jobs are plentiful, and so is burnout.
Federal funds rate	4.25–4.50%	Seven rate hikes in 2022. Mortgages are near 6.4%.
Average gas price	About $3.20 a gallon	Down from the $5.02 record of June 2022.
National debt	About $31.4 trillion	It hits the legal limit on Jan 19, 2023.
Stock market (2022)	S&P 500 down about 19%, Nasdaq down about 33%	The worst year since 2008. (Donohue stock (DON) still finished up.)
Bitcoin	About $16,500	Crypto winter after FTX collapsed in Nov 2022. Marc's 625,000 BTC are worth about $10B, and he hasn't sold a single coin.
Public mood	About 3 in 4 Americans say the country is on the wrong track	Angry, tired, and looking for something new.

2. The Political Landscape

Washington on Jan 1, 2023

- **The 118th Congress** convenes Tue Jan 3, 2023. **House:** 222 Republicans, 212 Democrats, 1 vacancy. Kevin McCarthy is about to need 15 ballots to become Speaker. **Senate:** 51–49, counting 48 Democrats and 3 independents (Bernie Sanders, Angus King, and Kyrsten Sinema, who left the Democratic Party on Dec 9, 2022). Majority Leader Chuck Schumer, Minority Leader Mitch McConnell. House Democrats are now led by Hakeem Jeffries, the first Black party leader in congressional history.
- **Supreme Court (6–3 conservative):** Chief Justice Roberts, Thomas, Alito, Sotomayor, Kagan, Gorsuch, Kavanaugh, Barrett, and Jackson (the first Black woman on the Court, seated June 30, 2022). *Dobbs* (June 24, 2022) overturned *Roe*.
- **Governors:** 26 Republicans, 24 Democrats. Key figures: DeSantis (FL), Newsom (CA), Abbott (TX), Kemp (GA), Whitmer (MI), Shapiro (PA, sworn in Jan 17).

- **The 2024 race on Jan 1, 2023:** only Donald Trump has declared (Nov 15, 2022, at Mar-a-Lago). Biden is expected to run but hasn't said so. DeSantis, fresh off a 19-point re-election, is the GOP's rising alternative.
- **Investigations:** the Jan. 6 Committee's final report (Dec 22, 2022) referred Trump to the DOJ. Special Counsel Jack Smith (appointed Nov 18, 2022) is investigating the documents case and Jan. 6. Biden's own classified-documents story breaks Jan 9, 2023.

Why a Celebrity Candidate Is a Hard Sell Right Now (Not Nerfed)

- The 2022 midterms **punished celebrity candidates**: TV doctor Mehmet Oz lost the Pennsylvania Senate race to John Fetterman, and football legend Herschel Walker lost Georgia's Senate runoff to Raphael Warnock (Tue Dec 6, 2022). In our timeline, Cornelius Smilley's Georgia Voters League helped turn out Warnock's base.
- Trump's 2016 win made celebrity candidates possible, and his presidency made millions of voters swear "never again." Marc inherits both feelings.
- The Reagan and Schwarzenegger precedents prove actors can govern, which is Marc's counter-argument.

3. The Year That Just Ended: 2022 in Review

Date (2022)	Real event (canon)	In our timeline
Feb 24	Russia invades Ukraine.	Donohue pulls all business from Russia within 24 hours (the first major company to do so). The Donohue Foundation funds refugee aid.
Mar 27	The 94th Academy Awards ("The Slap"). Will Smith wins Best Actor.	Broadcast on ABC, a Donohue network. Marc was a Best Actor nominee that night and lost to Smith, his second Oscar loss after Cornelius's whisper campaign.
Apr 22	Florida dissolves a major entertainment company's special self-governing district after its CEO opposed the "Don't Say Gay" bill.	It's **Donohue's Sunrise Improvement District** around Donohue World. Natasha vs. DeSantis is an open war heading into 2023.
May	Nationwide baby-formula shortage.	A "Marc Move": he flew formula in from Europe before the FDA finished its paperwork and dared regulators to stop him (see Section 7).
May 24	Uvalde school shooting.	Marc paid for every victim's funeral and has quietly funded the families since.
Jun 24	*Dobbs* decision.	
Aug 16	Inflation Reduction Act signed.	
Sep 8	Queen Elizabeth II dies. Charles III becomes King.	
Sep–Dec	Protests sweep Iran after the death of Mahsa Amini in police custody.	
Oct 27	Elon Musk buys Twitter.	Marc (640M Instagram followers) is the platform's most-followed holdout, and refuses to say why.
Nov 8	Midterms: Democrats hold the Senate, and Republicans narrowly win the House.	
Nov 11	FTX collapses.	Marc was never in it.
Nov 11 / Dec 16	*Black Panther: Wakanda Forever* and *Avatar: The Way of Water* open.	Both are **Donohue releases** (via Marvel and 20th Century). Donohue closes 2022 with the top two films of the holiday season.
Nov 30	OpenAI releases ChatGPT.	Hollywood's AI panic begins. Donohue's own AI division makes Natasha a target in the coming labor fight.
Dec 13	Respect for Marriage Act signed.	
Dec 21–30	Winter Storm Elliott. Southwest Airlines meltdown.	

Date (2022)	Real event (canon)	In our timeline
Dec 29–31	Netanyahu returns to power (Dec 29). Pelé dies (Dec 29). Pope Emeritus Benedict XVI dies (Dec 31).	

4. The World on Jan 1, 2023

Country / bloc	Leader (age)	Situation
China	Xi Jinping (69)	Began a third term in Oct 2022. Ended zero-COVID abruptly in Dec 2022, and a huge wave is sweeping the country. Taiwan tensions are high since Pelosi's Aug 2022 visit.
Russia	Vladimir Putin (70)	Ten months into a war in Ukraine that he expected to last days. Partial mobilization began Sep 2022.
Ukraine	Volodymyr Zelenskyy (44)	Addressed Congress on Dec 21, 2022. Holding the line.
North Korea	Kim Jong Un (38)	Fired a record number of missiles in 2022. Debuted his daughter, Kim Ju Ae (9 in canon), in Nov 2022.
Iran	Ali Khamenei (83)	Facing the largest protests in decades.
Canada	Justin Trudeau (51)	A future North American Union partner.
Mexico	Andrés Manuel López Obrador (69)	A future North American Union partner. Next election in June 2024.
United Kingdom	PM Rishi Sunak (42), King Charles III (74)	Its third prime minister of 2022.
Brazil	Lula da Silva (77)	**Inaugurated on Jan 1, 2023**, the day our story opens.
Israel	Benjamin Netanyahu (73)	Back in office since Dec 29, 2022, leading the most right-wing government in its history.
European Union	Commission President Ursula von der Leyen (64)	Croatia joins the euro on Jan 1, 2023.

5. The Divergence Ledger: How Our World Differs Before April 20, 2023

#	Divergence	Ripple effect
1	**The Walt Disney Company never existed.** Donohue Entertainment (founded 1923) took its place.	**IP rule:** anything Disney itself *created* (its mouse, its princesses, its in-house animated classics) doesn't exist. Donohue originals stand in its place. Anything Disney *acquired* (Pixar, Marvel, Lucasfilm and Star Wars, ABC, ESPN, 20th Century, FX, Hulu, National Geographic) exists, owned by Donohue.
2	**A Black-owned company has sat at the top of American culture for a century.**	Donohue Dreamland was integrated in 1956 and became a civil-rights landmark. Generations of children of every race grew up on Benny Bluebird. Black wealth and representation in Hollywood are visibly further along than in real life, but the industry is still majority white at most levels.
3	**Donohue is the most valuable company on Earth ($1.5T).**	Rivals are smaller than in real life: Apple about $1.42T, Saudi Aramco about $1.38T, Microsoft about $1.31T. Stability in Burbank: Natasha has been CEO for 16 years while rival studios churn through executives.
4	**Marc-Anthony Bullock is the richest person in history** (about $990B+).	Number two on the 2023 billionaire lists (Arnault or Musk, about $180–210B) is roughly $780B behind. He's the first person ever on track to become a trillionaire, and a regular business-press headline.
5	**The Smilleys are a Georgia political dynasty.**	Cornelius Smilley held a metro Atlanta House seat from 1993 to 2009 and bid for DNC Chair in Jan 2017 (withdrew before the Feb 25 vote). The Georgia Voters League is a recognized force in Southern Democratic politics.

#	Divergence	Ripple effect
6	**Fictional companies and shows exist** alongside real ones.	Meridian Pictures, Bullock Holdings, Smilley Strategies, *Marc My Words*, *Kid Mayor*, *Esther Ever After*, *Justice Cole*, and *Pulpit* (1997).
7	**Real events with our characters inside them**	For example: Marc's Oscar losses in 2020 and 2022, his "Marc Moves" during real disasters, and Donohue (instead of Disney) fighting Florida.

6. The Donohue-Verse: Culture Everyone Shares

- **Benny Bluebird** (since 1928) is the most recognized cartoon character on Earth. Saying "Take flight!" before a big moment is an American habit.
- **The Donohue Animation canon:** *The Firebird Princess* (1937). The Renaissance years: *Moonchild* (1989), *Queen of the Nile* (1991), and *Sundiata* (1996), a West African epic and the highest-grossing animated film of the 1990s. *Frostlight* (2013), whose power ballad "Let It Glow" every parent in America has heard 10,000 times. *Mariposa* (2021), the musical about a Colombian family that's still on every playlist in 2023.
- **"Bluebird kids"** is the nickname for Donohue Channel child stars. Marc, Esther, and Tayia are the most famous Bluebird kids ever. The "Bluebird curse" (child stars who flame out) is a tabloid staple, and Jaxon Wilde is its poster boy.
- **Donohue+** is the default streaming app in American homes. "Did you see it on Plus?" is everyday slang.
- **Bluebird Scholars:** more than one million Americans have gone to college on Donohue Foundation scholarships since 1947, including judges, CEOs, and members of Congress. Many will be quiet Marc supporters.
- **The Sunrise Tower**, the spire at the center of every Donohue park, is the wedding venue of the American imagination (Marc and Esther married there on June 15, 2013).

7. Hollywood & the Media Landscape

Hollywood in early 2023

- **The streaming wars** have peaked. Subscriber growth is slowing, and Wall Street now demands profits. Donohue+ and Hulu (about 320M combined) lead, followed by Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Max, Paramount+, and Peacock.
- **Labor storm on the horizon:** the Writers Guild contract expires May 1, 2023, and SAG-AFTRA's expires June 30, 2023. AI and streaming residuals are the flashpoints. Donohue, the largest studio, will sit across the table from its own most famous actor: Natasha vs. Marc, mother vs. son.
- **Black Hollywood** is stronger than in real life thanks to the Donohue century, but still fighting typecasting, the "one Black lead per slate" mentality, and pay gaps. White executives such as Gideon Kessler of Meridian still run most of the other studios.
- **The box office** is recovering from COVID, and Donohue owns the biggest franchises (Marvel, Star Wars, Pixar, *Avatar*).

Media & the Internet

- **Twitter**: chaos under Musk, with blue-check controversies and an exodus of advertisers. It's where politics happens and where Marc conspicuously isn't.
- **Instagram**: Marc's home base (about 640M followers, the most of any person on the platform).
- **TikTok**: about 150M U.S. users and a national-security fight in Congress. The twins aren't allowed on it (they're raised as Millennials).
- **YouTube, Twitch, podcasts**: the right-wing and left-wing podcast ecosystems are huge. Jaxon Wilde launches his anti-Marc podcast in 2023.

- **Cable news**: Fox News (Tucker Carlson's 8 PM show is the top-rated in cable news), CNN under new leadership, MSNBC. ABC News is a Donohue property, a conflict-of-interest storyline once Marc runs.
- **Gossip and culture media**: tabloid sites, Black culture Instagram pages, and stan Twitter. Marc's fandom calls itself **"The Bullpen."**
- **Polling**: the real pollsters (Gallup, Pew, Quinnipiac, Emerson, Marist, Morning Consult) all appear in the story. No one has ever polled Marc for President, because no one has thought to.

8. Marc-Anthony's Public Legend on Jan 1, 2023

To the public, Marc is America's beloved, unfiltered, absurdly rich big brother. Every American has a "Marc story." His charity record is enormous, and his habit of **bending ridiculous rules to help people** (the "Marc Move") is legendary. He has never held, or sought, public office.

Year	"Marc Move" (fictional actions during real events)
2015	**The Flint water crisis.** Hired private crews to start replacing lead pipes while permits were still "under review"; paid the fines and replaced the pipes.
2017	**Hurricane Maria.** Sailed a relief flotilla toward Puerto Rico before the Jones Act waiver (Sep 28, 2017) and publicly dared anyone to stop it.
2019	Paid off student lunch debt nationwide, then sued a district that tried to refuse the money.
2020	**COVID.** A PPE airlift from Asia while the federal stockpile lagged; paid rent for about 100,000 families.
2021	**Texas Winter Storm Uri.** Shipped generators and heaters around grid red tape.
2022	**The baby-formula shortage.** Flew formula from Europe before FDA clearance and told the FDA, "Arrest me after they've eaten." The FDA approved the shipments two days later.

- **Opposition-research flip side (not nerfed):** every Marc Move is also a story about a billionaire defying federal law, and Cornelius's "Bullock File" has catalogued all of them.
- **His comedy:** sold-out comedy specials, unhinged and offensive, beloved and also boycotted. The "Brother Cornelius" bit (2017) is a meme classic.

9. Atlas of Key Locations

Location	Where	Significance
Sunrise Hill	Bel Air, Los Angeles	Marc, Esther, and the twins' estate. Site of Lyric's 9th birthday party and the announcement.
Baldwin Hills	Los Angeles	"The Black Beverly Hills." Where Marc and Amond grew up next door to each other.
Donohue Studios lot	Burbank, CA	Corporate headquarters since 1940. Natasha's office overlooks the Benny Bluebird water tower.
Donohue Dreamland	Anaheim, CA	The first park (1956), with the original Sunrise Tower.
Donohue World Resort	Orlando, FL	The front line of the war with DeSantis over the Sunrise Improvement District.
Smilley House	Cascade Heights, Atlanta	The family seat. Odessa's parlor, with Josiah's portrait over the mantel.
Greater Mount Calvary Baptist	Atlanta	Josiah's pulpit, still the Smilley power base.
Georgia Voters League HQ	Sweet Auburn, Atlanta	The "Smilley Machine."
Smilley Strategies	K Street, Washington, D.C.	Cornelius's lobbying empire. "The Bullock File" is in a safe in Atlanta.
Meridian Pictures	Culver City, CA	Gideon Kessler's studio, Donohue's chief rival.
Bullock Holdings	Century City, Los Angeles	Marc's private conglomerate.

10. Glossary of the World

Term	Meaning
The Marc Move	Bending or breaking an unjust or ridiculous rule to help people. Praise or insult, depending on who says it.
The Bullpen	Marc's fanbase.
Bluebird kid	A Donohue Channel child star.
Take flight!	A Benny Bluebird catchphrase and everyday American good-luck phrase.
Plus	Donohue+, the streaming service.
The Smilley Machine	The Georgia Voters League's get-out-the-vote operation.
The Bullock File	Cornelius's 400-page opposition dossier on Marc.
Black don't crack	Why nobody in this story looks their age, and why the internet is constantly shocked by it.
Big Mama	What the twins call Odessa Smilley.

11. World-Building Canon Rules

- Real events up to April 20, 2023 happen exactly as in real life unless our characters or companies are involved. After that, real history is the baseline, and changes ripple out from Marc's run.
- Real people speak and act in character, at full competence. Nobody is nerfed.
- Every Disney reference in real-world history is a Donohue reference in ours (ownership, broadcasts, parks, releases, lawsuits).
- Story day two, **Mon Jan 2, 2023**: Bills safety Damar Hamlin collapses on *Monday Night Football*, broadcast on ESPN, a Donohue network. That makes it one of the first real events our characters live through on-screen.